

more than doubled, from 1,957 to a high of 4,546. Harshad's prophecy about ACC did come true – the stock touched Rs 10,500 on the day the Sensex peaked. It was indeed a price beyond anybody's imagination.

Harshad celebrated his triumph over the bear cartel by actually feeding peanuts to a bear in the city zoo, and getting that recorded by the video magazine *Newstrack*. Some of the old-timers felt he had overreached himself by publicly humiliating his rivals in this way.

Over the three months of the bull run, I made close to Rs 3.5 lakh. In the meantime, my relationship with Harshad had frayed. After that somewhat tentative start with him, we had begun to get closer. On a few occasions, I had got good deals for him, which he appreciated. He also trusted me enough to give me open-ended orders to buy shares for him, certain that I would not betray him.

A couple of people in his inner circle resented my growing proximity to him. Sharma hinted about them to me but did not name them, but I had a fair idea who he was referring to. Once in a while I would go short on some of the Big Bull's favourites. This was faithfully relayed to him. I do not think he would have taken offence to that, though it did mean I was challenging his judgement in taking an opposite position. But he was informed that my loyalty lay with the bear cartel. Since I got along well with Manubhai and did some trades for him as well, some thought of it as more than just a business relationship.

Then, on one occasion, I got a really poor price for a block of shares he had asked me to sell for him, despite my best efforts. His cronies told him that I was regularly ripping him off on deals. Earlier, I could pick up the phone and speak to him directly whenever I had a block of shares he was interested in. But now a wall seemed to be gradually growing between us. He was either too caught up with bigger things to spare time on small fry like me, or he had begun to suspect me because of the tales he was being fed. Once I had a good block on offer and called his office to inform him about it. His dealer came on the line and told me that they would get back. They never did. Two days later, I learnt that they had done the deal through somebody else. This happened once again, and by now I was really mad at the shoddy manner in which I was being treated. It would be a long time before I would speak to Harshad again.

The reckless manner in which Harshad was ramping up his stocks meant that he was pushing his luck too far. People say that had he slowed down a